

give 4 excellent reviews after your stay. This gives you room to negotiate for a lower rate also.

2. **Tripadvisor Rentals:** New options that don't exist elsewhere. Never understood why people would post their listings only here.

Pro tip: *How to pull down the rates:*

Since there are so many listings for paid stays, I usually hunt multiple avenues on several sites at once. I start contacting hosts, 2 months prior to the trip. I write an email saying:

“Hey [Host],

Trust you're doing great. Loved your listing and would be happy to stay between 9th-14th Feb. I see you've backpacked to Serbia while I was in Czech the same time. I feel we'd have a great time talking about backpacking experiences; plus, I'm very clean and will leave your space better than I found it.

I noticed it's a vacant slot and am pre-registering my interest.

The big problem is: your listing price would drain my budget within a couple of days!

What I suggest: If nothing else turns up until a week before, I'd love to stay and still pay half of what you've advertised.

If it's not possible, no worries. I'm all game. Thank you for patiently reading through.

Looking forward to merrier days!

- Pranav Surya ”

Most people agree to this warm approach. In big cities like San Francisco, my friends follow a 2-day waiting list instead of a week. Airbnb is still nascent in India and you can use the same email and get better success rates. Plus ‘*athithi devo bhava*’ still holds true in a lot of households and people accept lower rates if you're a great guest.